

# Final Project Checkpoint 1: Topic and Hypothesis

DUE September 17 at 5 PM

For the first checkpoint, you will propose a topic and explain a hypothesis regarding the relationship between an independent and dependent variable. This will involve three steps.

1. **First**, select one research question from the list below. There are 5 options for American Politics, 5 options for Comparative Politics, and 5 options for International Relations. Each research question comes with a ready-to-use dataset. Your job is to choose a topic that interests you and use the provided dataset to answer the research question.

## American Politics Topics:

- (a) How does a candidate's ideological moderation influence voters' perceptions of their electability in U.S. elections?

*Data for this research question is from the following article:* Anderson, Sarah E., Barry C. Burden, Daniel M. Butler, Laurel Harbridge-Yong, and Timothy J. Ryan. 2025. "Information and Perceptions of Electability in Primary Elections." *Political Behavior* 1-28.

**You can download the data from [here](#).**

- (b) How does partisan polarization in a state legislature affect legislative effectiveness?

*Data for this research question is from the following article:* Bucchianeri, Peter, Craig Volden, and Alan E. Wiseman. 2025. "Legislative Effectiveness in the American States." *American Political Science Review* 119(1): 21-39.

**You can download the data from [here](#).**

- (c) How does party identification influence Americans' beliefs about the frequency of election fraud in the U.S.?

*Data for this research question is from the following article:* Huber, Gregory A., John J. Cho, Scott E. Bokemper, Alan S. Gerber, William J. Brady, Killian McLoughlin, and Molly J. Crockett. 2025. "Disagreements About Threats to Electoral Integrity: Beliefs About the Severity and Frequency of Fraudulent, Uncounted, and Forgone Votes in the 2020 and 2024 Elections." *Political Behavior* 1-26.

**You can download the data from [here](#).**

- (d) How does prior elected experience influence candidates' success in U.S. elections?

*Data for this research question is from the following article:* Porter, Rachel, and Sarah A. Treul. 2025. "Evaluating (in) experience in congressional elections." *American Journal of Political Science* 69(1): 284-298.

**You can download the data from [here](#).**

- (e) How does voting by mail affect voters' ability to choose candidates who align with their preferences?

*Data for this research question is from the following article:* Wolak, Jennifer, and Carey E. Stapleton. 2025. "The Effects of Voting by Mail on Correct Voting." *Political Behavior* 1-18.

**You can download the data from [here](#).**

## Comparative Politics Topics:

- (a) How do political and economic conditions influence public trust in the armed forces across countries?  
*Data for this research question is from the following article:* Accorsi, Pedro, and Ronald R. Krebs. 2024. “The Soldier in the State: Explaining Public Trust in the Armed Forces.” *Comparative Political Studies*.  
**You can download the data from [here](#).**
- (b) How do major corruption scandals influence public support for democratic institutions?  
*Data for this research question is from the following article:* De Micheli, David, and Whitney K. Taylor. 2025. “Consequences of Corruption for Political System Support: Evidence From a Brazilian Scandal.” *Comparative Political Studies*.  
**You can download the data from [here](#).**
- (c) How does the urban–rural divide shape affective polarization?  
*Data for this research question is from the following article:* Hegewald, Sven, and Dominik Schraff. 2025. “Is the Urban-Rural Divide Affectively Polarised?” *Comparative Evidence from Nine European Countries.* *Comparative Political Studies*.  
**You can download the data from [here](#).**
- (d) How does exposure to political leaders’ criticism of democratic institutions affect citizens’ support for democracy?  
*Data for this research question is from the following article:* Cella, Lautaro, Ipek Cinar, Susan Stokes, and Andres Uribe. 2025. “Building Tolerance for Backsliding by Trash-Talking Democracy: Theory and Evidence from Mexico.” *Comparative Political Studies*.  
**You can download the data from [here](#).**
- (e) How do anti-government protests influence public support for political leaders in democracies?  
*Data for this research question is from the following article:* Yeandle, Alex, and David Doyle. 2025. “Protest and Incumbent Support: Evidence From a Natural Experiment in Ghana.” *Comparative Political Studies*.  
**You can download the data from [here](#).**

## International Relations Topics:

- (a) How do differences in economic opportunities between groups affect the occurrence of terrorism?

*Data for this research question is from the following article:* Piazza, James A. 2011. "Poverty, Minority Economic Discrimination, and Domestic Terrorism." *Journal of Peace Research* 48(3): 339-353.

**You can download the data from [here](#).**

- (b) How do political alliances between countries influence their trade with one another?

*Data for this research question is from the following article:* De Haim, Dotan A. 2016. "Alliance Networks and Trade: The Effect of Indirect Political Alliances on Bilateral Trade Flows." *Journal of Peace Research* 53(3): 472-490.

**You can download the data from [here](#).**

- (c) How does the internationalization of a civil war affect rebel groups' perpetration of human rights abuses?

*Data for this research question is from the following article:* Walsh, James Igoe, Justin M. Conrad, and Beth Elise Whitaker. 2024. "Rebel Human Rights Abuses During Civil Wars: Introducing the Rebel Human Rights Violations Dataset." *Journal of Peace Research* 61(3): 477-488.

**You can download the data from [here](#).**

- (d) How do visits by U.S. presidents and other senior officials affect conflicts between countries?

*Data for this research question is from the following article:* McManus, Roseanne W., and Tuba Sendiç. 2025. "Sending the B Team: The Impact of Lesser Signals of Resolve." *Journal of Peace Research* 62(3): 580-594.

**You can download the data from [here](#).**

- (e) How do the characteristics of terrorist attacks shape public concern about them?

*Data for this research question is from the following article:* Kantorowicz, Jaroslaw, Elena Kantorowicz-Reznichenko, and Gerdien de Vries. 2025. "Public Perception of Terrorism Attacks: A Conjoint Experiment." *Journal of Peace Research* 62(2): 310-327.

**You can download the data from [here](#).**

You will use the dataset linked to your chosen topic for the rest of the semester, so pick something you're genuinely interested in learning more about.

2. **Second**, find peer-reviewed social science articles related to your topic. Google Scholar (<http://scholar.google.com>) is a great place to start. You may also use news articles and other sources to provide background, but you must reference at least four peer-reviewed articles in your literature review.
3. **Third**, write a 2–3 page literature review that includes a theory and testable hypothesis. Your literature review should summarize key research on your topic, synthesize the arguments and findings, and explain why this prior research leads you to your hypothesis. Structure it like the literature review or theory sections in the academic articles we've read. Be sure to address:
  - 1) the authors' theories,
  - 2) how they tested their hypotheses,
  - 3) their results, and
  - 4) how these elements are similar or different across studies.

Strong literature reviews will also critically assess the research designs or theories you discuss (e.g., strengths, weaknesses, or generalizability).

Most importantly, successful assignments will:

- Summarize the current literature on your topic.
- Provide a theory or argument motivated by the literature.
- Propose a hypothesis implied by your theory.

**Please print your research question and hypothesis in bold at the top of your submission!**

# Grading Rubric for Final Project Checkpoint 1

Total Points: 2

## 1. Topic Selection (0.5 points)

- **0.5 points:** Topic is one of the provided options.
- **0 points:** Topic is stated but is not from the provided list.

## 2. Theory and Hypothesis (0.5 points)

- **0.5 points:** Theory is well-developed, logically derived from relevant literature. Hypothesis is clearly stated, testable, and printed in bold.
- **0.25 points:** Theory is present but underdeveloped or weakly connected to the literature. Hypothesis is stated but not clearly testable or not printed in bold.
- **0 points:** Theory and hypothesis are missing or not linked to the literature.

## 3. Literature Review (1 point)

- **1 point:** Comprehensive literature review with at least four peer-reviewed sources. Strong synthesis and critical assessment.
- **0.75 points:** Meets the minimum source requirement but synthesis or assessment is limited.
- **0.5 points:** Fewer than four peer-reviewed sources or weak synthesis.
- **0.25 points:** Incomplete review with minimal effort.
- **0 points:** Missing literature review.